Remarks by the President of the European Parliament Roberta Metsola
European Council
Brussels, 18 June 2026

Dear colleagues,

There are moments when Europe sends a message that is stronger than any statement, declaration or speech. Opening the first cluster of chapters in the accession negotiations with Ukraine and the Republic of Moldova is one of those moments.

The message is that enlargement is no longer a distant promise. It is here, it is happening, and the European Parliament has pushed for this for years. And we have consistently kept the Western Balkans high on the European Union's agenda. Two days ago, Montenegro announced that it has provisionally closed two more negotiating chapters. And just this week, Parliament adopted five more progress reports on Montenegro, Albania, Kosovo, North Macedonia and Bosnia and Herzegovina. We need to deliver. We don't have the luxury of time.

Because we understand that enlargement is not only about those who join. It is also about what sort of Union they join. And when done properly, it strengthens Europe as a whole. Enlargement is a win-win. We need to keep repeating that.

The path remains long. But whether we are talking about Ukraine, Moldova, Montenegro or any of the other Western Balkans, it would be a mistake to think that public support will simply appear at the end. We need to start making the case now.

That means taking people's fears and concerns seriously. It means addressing them honestly. And it means showing the tangible benefits that enlargement brings, so that we can build the confidence and trust needed to move forward. You can count on the European Parliament's support here.

I also want to mention this idea of gradual integration. Interim or associated "observer" formats can be useful, so can access to our Single Market when it is based on real progress in domestic reforms. These steps can bring countries closer to our Union. But they can never become a substitute for full EU membership.

The Parliament welcomes the renewed effort to find ways forward to find a resolution to the illegal war in Ukraine. There are two things that remain central to efforts: firstly the principle of 'Nothing about Ukraine without Ukraine' and secondly, that Europe will keep supporting Ukraine for as long as it takes.

The second point is about the Multiannual Financial Framework.

The European Parliament is ready.

We welcome the fact that the Cypriot Presidency has issued its negotiating box. Of course, it is normal that there are differences between our positions. Parliament will be constructive but will also defend its position. What we should avoid is brinkmanship. That is why my appeal remains to involve MEPs as much and as early as possible.

I will always defend parliament's prerogatives, and if we proceed in this spirit, there is no reason why we cannot try to reach an agreement by the end of the year.

And because we are still at the start of this process, I want to come back to the issue of new own resources. Because with them, we can finally move away from the tired debate of cuts versus increases. We all agree that we need an ambitious budget. We all agree that it must match the scale of the challenges we face. No one wants to place additional pressure on national budgets but let's not ignore the reality that these funds are economic drivers in themselves. Sometimes we get so caught up in old dividing lines that we miss the common ground in front of us. Maybe the solution, or at least part of the solution, we've been looking for is already there.

Now before I turn to competitiveness, let me also note that this week, the European Parliament passed the Return Regulation. With the Pact on Migration and Asylum in application, Europe now has the tools to address this challenge. We did our part. And we will deliver on the rest too. Like we managed to deliver on new Air Passenger Rights, thanks to the excellent cooperation between the institutions and the commitment of the rapporteurs, the Cypriot Presidency and everyone else involved.

It is also time to move on the interim Regulation to Prevent and Combat Child Sexual Abuse and look at how to find an agreement on a second reading of this file. Let me also underline the role of Outermost regions. They are part of Europe's strength, and we cannot afford to leave them behind.

On proxy voting for female MEPs during late pregnancy and early motherhood, Council has approved a targeted amendment to the European electoral law. It must now be ratified by all Member States, and we hope we can continue to count on your support to make that happen. If this enters into force, this reform will be a huge milestone for Parliament and for Europe. It will impact MEPs and send such an important signal.

Finally, on European competitiveness.

Over the past decade, the number of people working in Europe's tech sector increased by 60%. Over that same period, venture capital in the European Union has quadrupled. EU pension fund allocations to start-ups have increased by 55% in recent years. And their returns have been stronger too. European pension funds have outperformed their counterparts in the United States.

Three different examples from three different aspects of our economy, but they all point in the same direction. Investment is already happening. The question is whether we are ready to match that momentum with the right political decisions.

For the European Parliament, that is precisely where the 'One Europe, One Market' Roadmap adds value. Regularly reviewing the progress we are making on this Roadmap in our discussions here would be an excellent way to map progress and focus on delivering. And let me say that the European Parliament will not allow technical decisions to delay things.

So let me start with our side of the ledger. Since we last met, the European Parliament and Council have reached interinstitutional agreements on simplifying rules on artificial intelligence, midcaps, and the three defence files designed to accelerate investments, speed-up

permit-granting and make intra-EU transfers and procurement easier. We will already vote on the first two in our plenary in two and a half weeks.

On removing barriers in our Single Market, the Market Integration and Supervision package and EU Inc. are our two flagship projects. They go directly to the biggest concerns companies raise with us and are priority files for the European Parliament. We will look further at the social dimension as well.

On trade, this week the European Parliament voted in favour of the EU-US trade deal, and it did so with an overwhelming majority. That gives the agreement strong political weight and a real solid basis to build upon.

On energy, the European Parliament welcomes the announcement of an agreement between the United States and Iran to restore freedom of navigation and reopen the Strait of Hormuz. We hope that it will be implemented swiftly and fully by all parties. In the European Parliament, we will continue to push for greater storage capacity, stronger infrastructure and grids, a more diversified energy mix, and reduced external dependence. Our course has not changed.

As we are almost halfway through the year, I also looked at the progress of our files in the Joint Declaration on EU legislative priorities for 2026. And I am happy to inform you that the European Parliament and Council are moving in sync.

Thank you.